



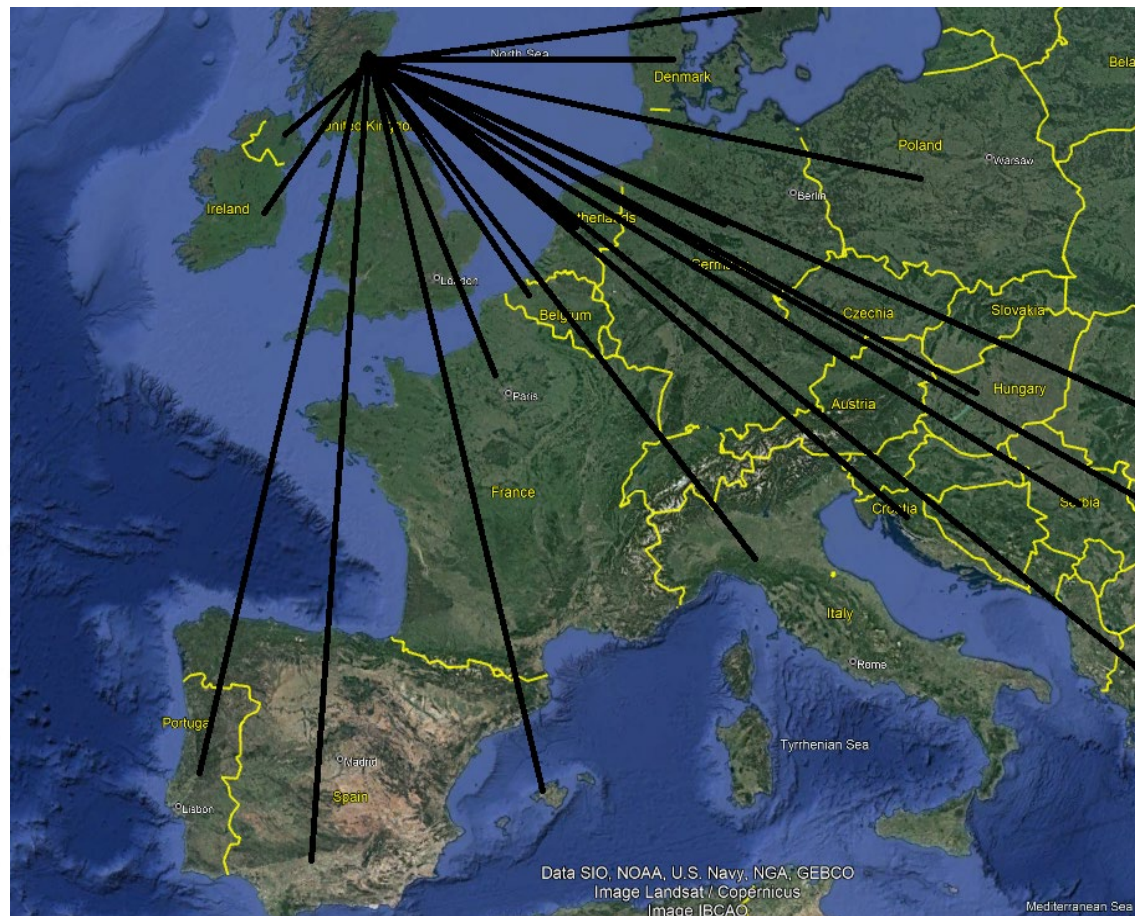
Seed Potatoes and Brexit

An update

Douglas Harley - Cygnet Potato Breeders Ltd/BSPB

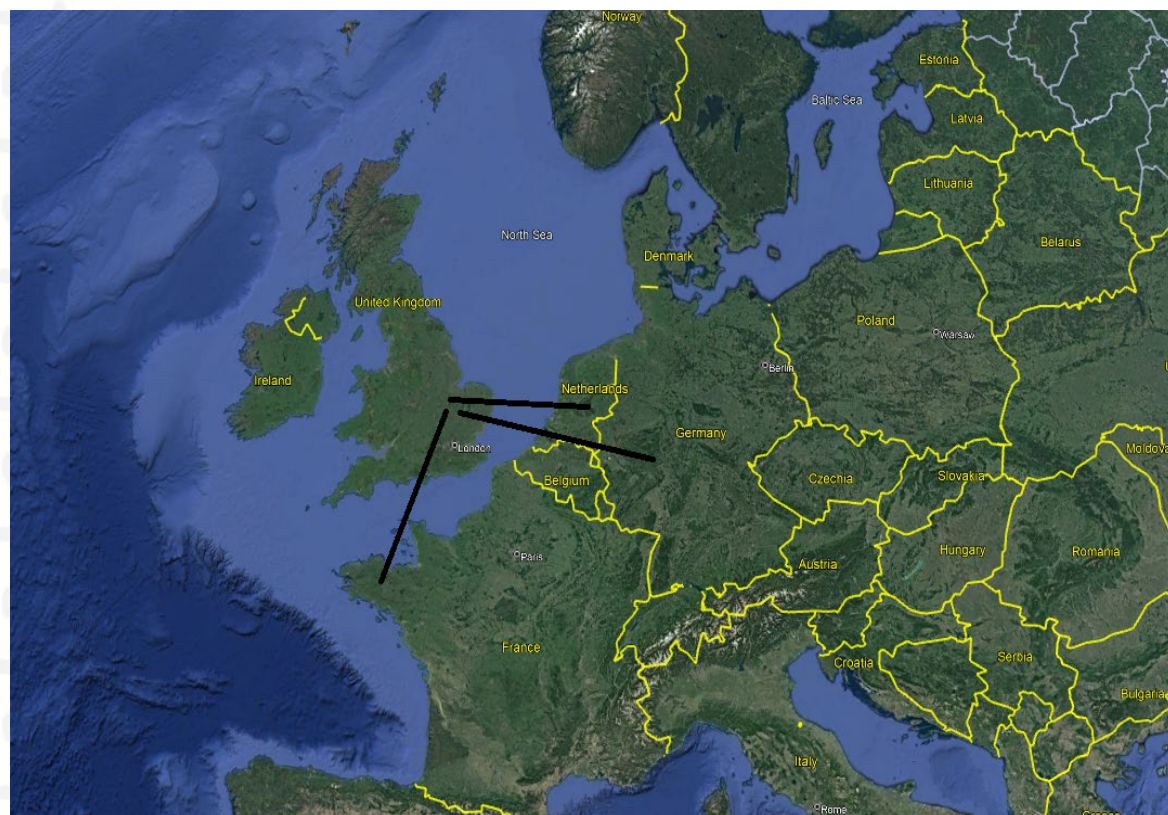


How it used to be - UK to Europe



- Scotland has lowest virus levels in Europe, 97% of seed area class SE or better.
- High grade seed production then sent for further multiplication in Europe, often controlled supply chains – breeders and multinational processors.
- Traditional markets Ireland, Northern Ireland, Spain, Canary Islands.
- Movement of trial seed of new varieties.
- Approx 25,000 tonnes of seed exported per year.
- Further multiplication within Europe to create additional 80,000 tonnes of seed per year.

How it used to be - Europe to UK



- Mainly class A seed for table, processing and chip shop production in England.
- Often varieties that didn't suit production in Scotland.
- Small amount of high grade for seed production in England.
- Movement of trial seed of new varieties.
- Approx 25,000 tonnes of seed per year.

Legal position following Brexit

● From UK to Europe

- Certified seed potatoes are not allowed from third countries, plant health directive.
COUNCIL DIRECTIVE 2000/29/EC:REGULATION (EU) 2016/2031
- No equivalence in certification standards so seed cannot be marketed.
- New applications for CC and PBR must now be made in EU.

● From Europe to UK

- No equivalence in certification standards so seed cannot be marketed.
- New applications for NL and PBR must now be made in UK.

Desired outcomes following Brexit



Europe Wants

UK to dynamically align legislation to follow EU plant health and certification legislation



UK Wants

Recognition of equivalence in plant health and certification legislation between UK and EU

Plant health considerations

- Ring Rot (*Clavibacter michiganensis* subsp. *Sepedonicus*)

(2022 – 11 member states)

- Brown Rot (*Ralstonia solanacearum*),

(2022 – 8 member states)

- Potato flea beetle (*Epitrix*),

Spain and Portugal

- Specific strain of blackleg (*Dickeya dadanti*)

(only Scotland has zero tolerance)

- Root-knot nematode (*Meloidogyne chitwoodi*)

widespread in Europe

- **All present in Europe but not in Scotland**

Result = Stalemate

- UK applied in January 2021 under Article 44 of the 2016 Regulations for a recognition of equivalence. Request ignored by SCoPAFF because of 3rd country ban.
- March 2022 – European Parliament Agriculture Committee – Exchange of views on the disruption in EU-GB trade in seed potatoes – no progress.
- DEFRA, at the Trade and Cooperation Agreement Partnership Council in June 2022, asked in particular for a risk assessment justifying the ban on plant health grounds. – but

“the assessment of the UK’s sanitary and phytosanitary regime for the purpose of listing it as a third country allowed to export food products to the EU? These are unilateral decisions of the EU and are not subject to negotiation”.

- Recurring Agenda item at ScoPAFF meeting - A.12 Information on import-export issues between the EU and UK(GB) – no discussion.

Result = Stalemate

ScoPAFF could grant a derogation for Scottish seed at any time and remove it if a plant health threat emerges.



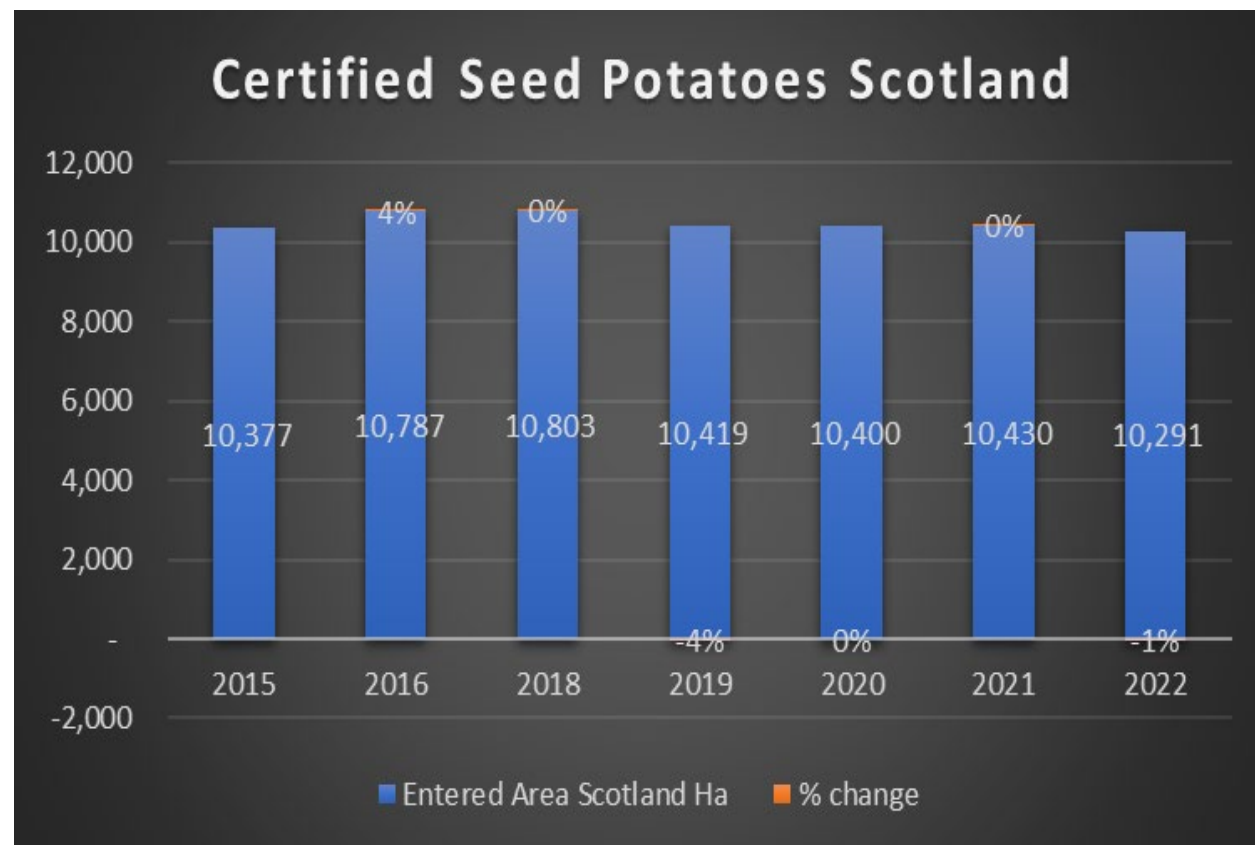
Brexit Outcomes - Scotland

Before Brexit the area required for European sales was approx. 1000Ha.

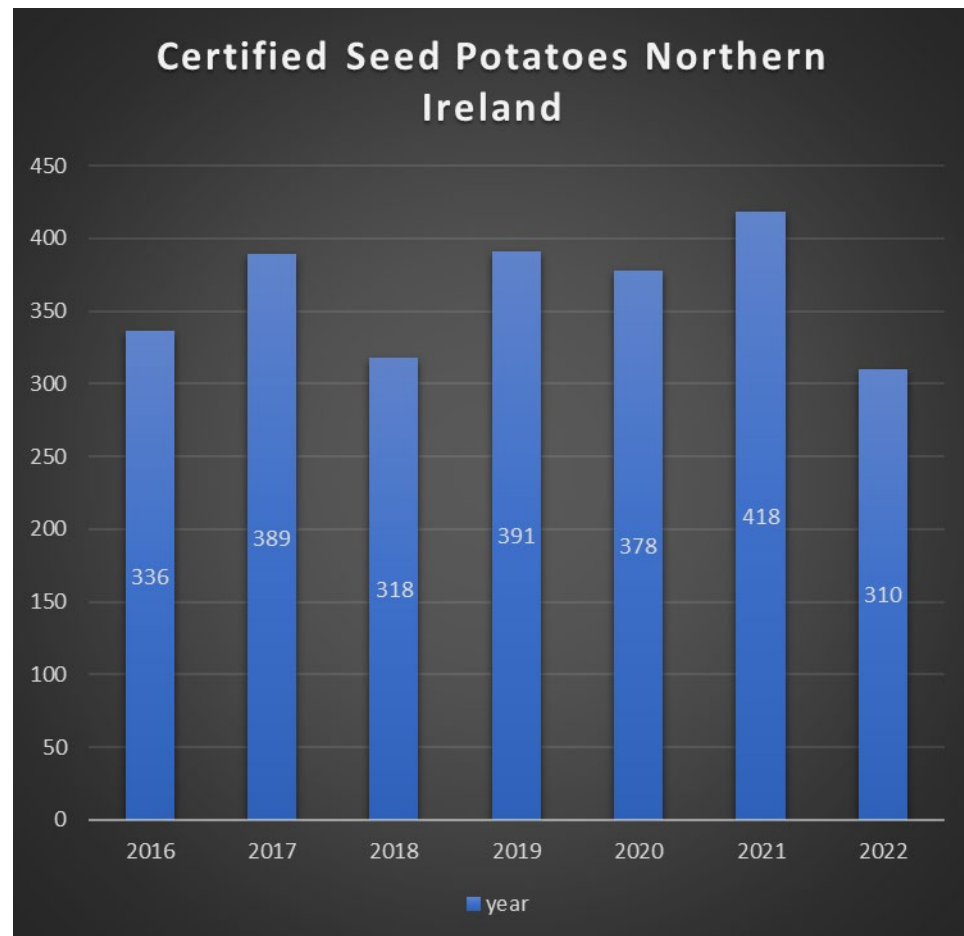
Alternative markets found?

UK

Outside Europe



Brexit Outcomes – Northern Ireland



- Northern Ireland Protocol prevents it from using Scottish Seed.
- Area has reduced since Brexit, lack of high grade.
- Northern Ireland has limited capacity for seed potato production. Land and climate constraints
- Continuing political unrest – Northern Ireland protocol.

Brexit Outcomes –Ireland



- Ireland pre-Brexit sourced 80% of its seed requirements from Scotland around 5000 tonnes.
- Domestic seed production has increased but only by around 1000 tonnes.
- Additional imports will have to come from Holland and France - additional plant health risks. In particular root-knot nematode and *Dikeya dadanti* (blackleg).
- Additional haulage costs.

Brexit Outcomes – Ireland

Imports of table potatoes from the UK to Ireland have been increasing – is Irish potato growing being exported to UK?

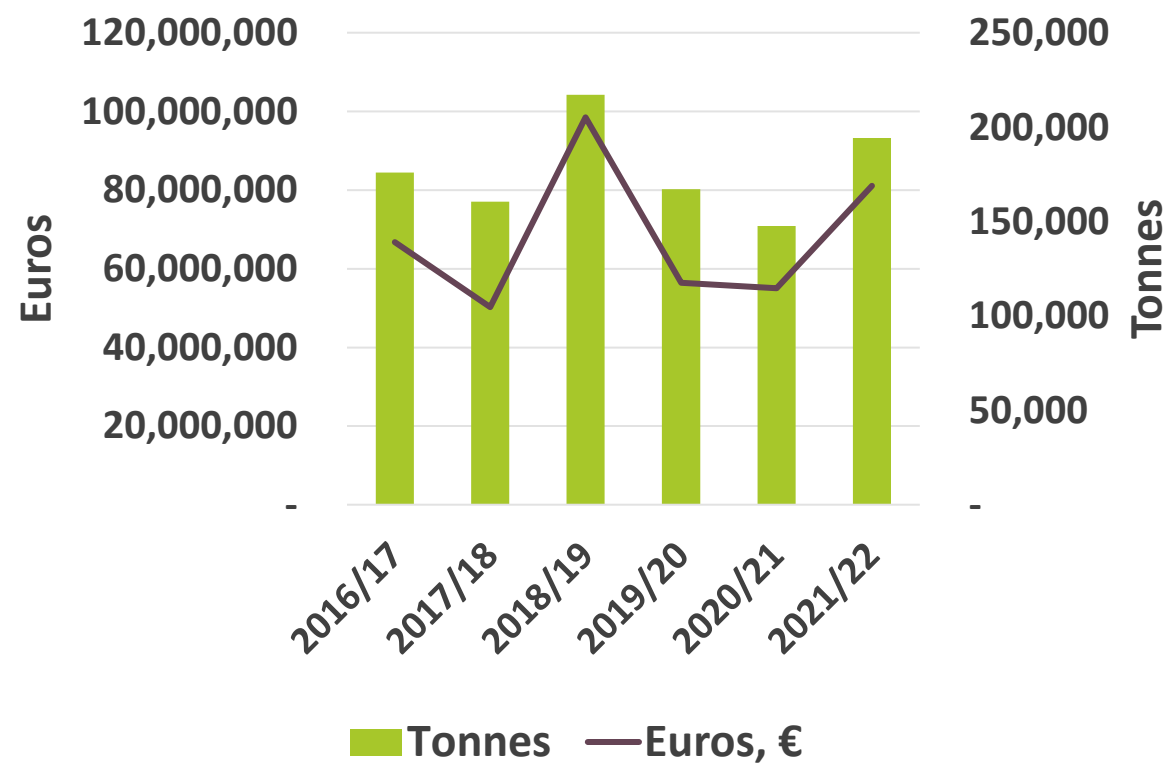
2021-2022 saw a 31% increase of 46,600 tonnes, equivalent to 1000Ha of production.

Increase in cost of over 26,000,000 Euros.

Area of Potatoes in Ireland Ha

2019	2020	2021	2022
8,247	8,840	7,800	7,400

UK ware potato exports to Ireland in years ending August



Summary of Outcomes

WINNERS

- EU Commission.
- Scotland.

LOSERS

- European Potato Industry.
- Ireland.
- Northern Ireland.
- Sustainability – more insecticides, more food miles, lower yields.



Thank-you

Douglas Harley - Cygnet Potato Breeders/BSPB

